

POLICYREADY • OHIO

How to Open a **Shared Living** **(Host Home) Business** in Ohio

Ohio's host-home model for adults with IDD — the realistic path, since new group homes aren't available

Step by Step

*From “where do I start?” to your first payment —
whether you go independent, or build your own agency.*

A complete, plain-language guide for real people — not lawyers or consultants.

Figures current for 2026 • Verify all details with the State of Ohio.

Read this first — an important Ohio reality

If you came here to “open a group home in Ohio,” start with this: Ohio caps the total number of licensed residential (group home) beds statewide, and that cap has been reached — so opening a brand-new licensed group home generally is not an option. The realistic way to open a home for adults with developmental disabilities in Ohio is Ohio Shared Living (formerly Adult Foster Care / Host Services), where a person lives with you and you're certified by DODD as a provider. That's what this guide walks you through — and knowing it now can save you months chasing a dead end. This is general information, not legal, tax, or billing advice; verify current details with DODD and your county board.

What this guide covers

- Part 0 — The big picture: what Shared Living is, the group-home reality, who the players are, and the two ways in.
- Part 1 — Path A: becoming a certified independent provider (the fastest, simplest start).
- Part 2 — Path B: becoming an agency provider (employ staff, serve more people).
- Part 3 — Who you need on your team.
- Part 4 — The home: what your house needs (and why Shared Living isn't a licensed facility).
- Part 5 — Getting your first person placed.
- Part 6 — How you get paid: the daily-rate system, the group-size math, and your first payment.
- Part 7 — What it costs and how long it takes.
- Part 8 — When they say “check locally”: who to call and exactly what to ask (Columbus & Cleveland worked out).

PART 0

The Big Picture

Opening a Shared Living home in Ohio is not like opening a normal small business, and the reason people get lost is that the information lives in a dozen different places. Here it is in one place.

What Ohio Shared Living actually is

Ohio Shared Living is a service under the Individual Options (IO) waiver in which an adult with an intellectual or developmental disability (IDD) lives with a certified provider — in your home or theirs — and you provide day-to-day support: help with cooking, cleaning, laundry, shopping, medical appointments, and personal care. It was formerly known as Adult Foster Care or Host Services. It is Ohio's version of a host home, and it's governed by Ohio Administrative Code rule 5123-9-33.

The group-home reality — read this before you spend a dollar

Ohio law limits the total number of licensed residential (group home) beds in the state, and that limit has been reached. In practice, that means you generally cannot open a brand-new licensed group home. Your realistic options for opening a home are: become a certified provider and offer Shared Living (this guide), be the owner/landlord of a home while a certified provider delivers services in it, or buy/take over an existing licensed operation. For most people starting out, Shared Living is the path — and it has a big advantage: because it happens in a private home and isn't a licensed facility, it avoids the bed cap entirely.

The players — learn these names, you'll deal with all of them

- DODD — the Ohio Department of Developmental Disabilities. It certifies providers, administers the waivers, and runs the billing systems.
- County board of DD — your local “front door” (Ohio has 88). It determines eligibility, and your Service and Support Administrator (SSA) writes the individual service plan and coordinates services.
- ODM — the Ohio Department of Medicaid (agency providers get a Medicaid site visit from ODM).
- The waivers — Individual Options (IO), Level One, and SELF. Shared Living is an IO-waiver service.
- PNM / PSM — the Provider Network Management portal (the single front door) that takes you into Provider Services Management to apply.

The fork in the road — there are two ways in

This decides your scale and your paperwork.

- Path A — Become a certified independent provider. You're self-employed, certified by DODD under your own name and SSN, you provide the services yourself (you can't employ others), and you bill DODD directly. Fastest, simplest, cheapest — this is how most people start.
- Path B — Become an agency provider. You form a business that employs staff, can serve more people, and is certified by DODD (with a Medicaid site visit from ODM). More setup and overhead, but it scales.

PART 1 • PATH A

Become a Certified Independent Provider

Start here. You can always grow into an agency later.

Step 1 — Make sure it fits your life

Shared Living means an adult with a developmental disability lives with you and you support them through everyday life. You must be at least 18, have a valid SSN and government ID, a high school diploma or GED, and be able to keep good records. Everyone's situation is different — sit with it honestly, and remember you'll be self-employed (you handle your own taxes).

Step 2 — Get your NPI number

Apply (free) for a National Provider Identifier through NPPES — you need it to even start the certification application, and you'll pick a taxonomy code during the process.

Step 3 — Complete your background checks

Get an Ohio BCI (Bureau of Criminal Investigation) background check at a WebCheck location using reason code 5123.169. If you've lived outside Ohio in the last five years, you also need an FBI check (code 5126.28). Results must be sent directly from the Attorney General's office to DODD (allow up to 45 days).

Step 4 — Do CPR/First Aid and the required training

Complete CPR and First Aid with an in-person assessment component (online-only doesn't meet DODD's requirement), and the Independent Provider Initial Training in DODD's MyLearning system (about 8 hours, per rule 5123-2-09). If you'll help with medications, you'll also complete Medication Administration certification.

Step 5 — Apply through PNM / PSM

Log in to the Provider Network Management (PNM) app on your OH|ID dashboard, choose “New Provider” → Medicaid Waiver (DODD), upload your documents, and submit. There's a certification fee (\$125 for three years), though DODD has been waiving it for new applicants — confirm the current status.

Step 6 — Get certified & notify your county board

DODD reviews your application and emails your certification (with your DODD provider number and dates). Then contact the county board where you (or the person you'll support) live, so they add you to the provider network.

Step 7 — Put your policies in writing

Even as an independent provider, you need clear documentation — how you handle medications, emergencies, incident reporting (Major Unusual Incidents), and the rights of the person you serve, plus your required substitute-coverage protocol. PolicyReady's Ohio manuals are built for exactly this: ready to customize, just add your details.

Step 8 — Get matched, bill, and get paid

The individual (with help from their SSA) chooses you as their provider — note the SSA can't recommend a specific provider, so this is the person's choice. Once services are authorized in PAWS, you deliver support, submit claims through eMBS, and get paid a daily rate (see Part 6). Within 60 days of certification you'll also take a short billing class.

PART 2 • PATH B

Become an Agency Provider

More setup, more capacity. Here's what's different from going independent.

What changes as an agency

- You form a business and employ staff. An agency provider employs at least one person besides the director of operations, so you can serve more people and cover more hours than a single independent provider.
- You're certified under rule 5123-2-08 (agency providers), not 5123-2-09 (independent providers) — with agency-level policies, an administrator, and training systems.
- ODM does a site visit. After DODD approves your application, it's sent to the Ohio Department of Medicaid, which conducts a site visit before your Medicaid provider agreement is finalized.
- You screen and train your staff. Every direct support professional needs the BCI/FBI checks, CPR/First Aid, and required training — the same standards you'd meet as an independent provider, applied to your whole team.

The backbone is the same

You still get an NPI, complete background checks, apply through PNM/PSM, get certified by DODD, and work with county boards to serve people. The difference is that you're building an organization — with employees, policies, and administration — rather than providing every service with your own hands. Many people start as an independent provider, learn the system, and then form an agency.

PART 3

Who You Actually Need (Staffing)

As an independent provider: you are the provider — you can't employ or subcontract others to deliver the service. What you must have is a written substitute-coverage protocol: a plan (and back-up people arranged with the individual's SSA) for who supports the person when you're sick, away, or need a break. Line that up before you start.

As an agency provider, plan for these roles — one person can wear several hats at the start:

- Director of operations / administrator — runs the agency and owns compliance and the DODD certification.
- Direct support professionals (DSPs) — the certified caregivers who deliver day-to-day support; each screened and trained.
- Registered Nurse — for medication oversight and delegation where needed; often part-time or contracted at first.
- Billing / administrative support — submits eMBS claims, verifies authorizations in PAWS, and tracks payments.

PART 4

The Home: What Your House Actually Needs

The good news about Shared Living

Shared Living happens in a private home — yours or the person's — and it is not a licensed residential facility. That's the whole reason it sidesteps Ohio's group-home bed cap, and it's why you don't need a commercial facility license or institutional fire-suppression system. What you do need is a safe, healthy home that meets the federal Home and Community-Based Settings requirements and treats the person as a tenant with rights, not a patient in a facility.

What the home needs to be

- Safe and healthy: working smoke and carbon-monoxide detectors, safe utilities and electrical, clean and sanitary conditions, and accessible exits — a normal safe home.
- A real home, with rights: under the HCBS Settings rule (Ohio rule 5123-9-02), the person has privacy, a lockable bedroom where appropriate, control over their own schedule and visitors, access to food at any time, and full access to the community — the setting can't be institutional.
- Small by nature: Shared Living is a family-home arrangement, and the number of people with developmental disabilities living in the home is limited (the rule itself only recognizes group sizes up to four, and most homes serve one or two). Confirm the current limit with your county board.
- Backed by a plan: you maintain your written substitute-coverage protocol and your service documentation in the home.

Two things people get wrong

- It's not a group home, and that's the point. Don't try to license a group home — the beds aren't available. Shared Living is the open door, and it's less regulated because it's a private residence, not a facility.
- Room and board is separate from your pay. The Shared Living daily rate does not include the person's room and board or the upkeep of the home — the person pays their own room and board (usually from SSI). Keep that separate from what you bill.

PART 5

Getting Your First Person Placed

You can't get paid until someone chooses you and services are authorized. Here's how that happens.

1. The person qualifies and has a waiver. The individual is found eligible by a county board and enrolled in the IO waiver (Ohio has waiting lists, so many people have waited for a funded slot). Shared Living is an IO-waiver service.
2. The SSA and team build the plan. The Service and Support Administrator develops the individual service plan and, using the Ohio Developmental Disabilities Profile (ODDP), determines the person's funding range — which sets your daily rate.
3. The person chooses you. Individuals have the right to choose their provider; the SSA can help with the process but cannot recommend or select a specific provider. Often a family already has someone in mind — sometimes a relative (you can be certified to serve your adult sibling or a relative, but not your own minor child).
4. Services are authorized in PAWS. The county board enters the authorization in the Payment Authorization for Waiver Services (PAWS) system. Claims must match PAWS, so confirm it's in place before you provide services.
5. Move-in / begin services. Once the person is living with you (or you with them) and services are authorized, you're delivering a billable service.

PART 6

How You Get Paid: The Daily Rate & Your First Payment

How the rate is built

Ohio Shared Living is paid at a daily rate under rule 5123-9-33 — not an hourly rate. Three things shape the number: the person's Ohio Developmental Disabilities Profile (ODDP) funding range (their assessed level of need), your county's cost-of-doing-business category (Ohio groups counties into cost tiers), and whether you're an independent provider or an agency provider (rates are set separately for each). The exact service code and current dollar amount live in Appendix A to rule 5123-9-33 — look up your ODDP range and county category there, or ask your county board.

The group-size math (a Shared Living quirk worth knowing)

If more than one person receiving services lives in the home, the daily rate per person steps down — because you're supporting them together. The percentages of the daily rate are:

People receiving services in the home	Daily rate paid, per person
1 person	100% of the daily rate
2 people	85% each
3 people	75% each
4 people	65% each

Also good to know: only one provider per day may bill Shared Living for a given person, and Shared Living can't be billed on the same day as residential respite, community respite (full day), or homemaker/personal care for that person.

How you bill — and two nice perks

- Billing system: independent providers bill DODD directly through eMBS (the enhanced Medicaid Billing System); your claim must match the authorization in PAWS.
- No EVV for Shared Living: Electronic Visit Verification is required for some services (like independent homemaker/personal care), but not for Shared Living — one less system to manage.
- A real tax perk: because you live with the person, your Shared Living payments may qualify for the IRS “difficulty-of-care” income exclusion — potentially non-taxable. Confirm with a tax professional.

Your first payment

6. Confirm the authorization is in PAWS (the right service, span, and rate).
7. Deliver support and keep your daily documentation.
8. Submit your claim in eMBS — it must match PAWS or it denies.
9. Get paid — and never balance-bill. Medicaid pays the service; the person owes only their own room and board.

PART 7

What It Costs & How Long It Takes

Timeline

The certification steps — NPI, background checks, CPR/First Aid, initial training, and the PNM/PSM application — can often be completed in a matter of weeks, with the biggest variable being the BCI/FBI background check (allow up to 45 days for results to reach DODD). Becoming an agency provider takes longer because of the ODM site visit. Confirm current processing times with DODD and your county board.

Startup line items

Independent provider costs are low: the NPI is free; background checks have a modest fee; CPR/First Aid and Medication Administration training have small costs; and the DODD certification fee is \$125 for three years (often waived for new applicants — confirm current status). An agency adds business formation, insurance, staff payroll, and more robust policies and procedures.

PART 8

When They Say “check Locally”: Who to Call & What to Ask

In Ohio, your county board is the center of gravity. Here's who to call and exactly what to ask, so you get a straight answer instead of getting bounced around.

The statewide offices (same for everyone)

For...	Contact
Provider certification & billing help	DODD Provider Support Center — 800-617-9733 · DODD.support@dodd.ohio.gov
Provider certification (mailing address)	DODD Provider Certification, 30 E. Broad St., 13th Floor, Columbus, OH 43215
Background checks (WebCheck)	Ohio Attorney General — ohioattorneygeneral.gov (BCI code 5123.169)
Rules, rates & the bill-code appendix	dodd.ohio.gov → Forms & Rules (rule 5123-9-33, Appendix A)
Find your county board	dodd.ohio.gov → Find Your County Board

The local calls — and what to ask on each one

① YOUR COUNTY BOARD OF DD — YOUR MOST IMPORTANT CALL

- “I want to become a Shared Living provider. How do I get on your provider network, and who is my provider-support contact?”
- “Are there individuals in this county looking for a Shared Living provider, and how does someone choose me?”
- “What’s the current waiting-list situation for the IO waiver here?”

② CITY OR COUNTY ZONING — USUALLY SIMPLE FOR SHARED LIVING

- “I’ll have one adult with a developmental disability live in my home and I’ll provide support (Ohio Shared Living — not a licensed group home). Is that allowed at my address as a normal residential use?”
- Because it’s a private home (not a facility), this is usually straightforward — but confirm any local rules, and know that homes for people with disabilities are protected as residential use under the federal Fair Housing Act.

Fully worked examples — Ohio's two biggest metros

Most people start in or near one of these two, so each one's real call list is done for you below. If you're elsewhere, use these as a template — and remember, once you're certified you can serve people anywhere in Ohio.

COLUMBUS (FRANKLIN COUNTY)

- County board: Franklin County Board of Developmental Disabilities (FCBDD) — 2879 Johnstown Road, Columbus, OH 43219; main (614) 475-6440; Provider Relations (614) 342-5975; 24-hour emergency (614) 464-2743.
- Certification: DODD Provider Support Center (800) 617-9733; apply through PNM/PSM on your OH|ID dashboard.
- Zoning: City of Columbus / Franklin County — Shared Living in a private home is normally a residential use; confirm your address.

CLEVELAND (CUYAHOGA COUNTY)

- County board: Cuyahoga County Board of Developmental Disabilities (Cuyahoga DD) — main (216) 241-8230; after-hours (216) 694-7077; eligibility/intake (216) 736-2673.

- Certification: same statewide DODD process (PNM/PSM); DODD Provider Support (800) 617-9733.
- Zoning: City of Cleveland / Cuyahoga County — confirm your address; again, Shared Living in a private home is normally residential use.

How to find your own county's numbers

10. Use DODD's "Find Your County Board" tool — your board is assigned by where you live.
11. Call your county board and ask for Provider Support / Provider Relations to get on the network.
12. For zoning, call your city or county and ask for Planning/Zoning; explain it's a private-home Shared Living arrangement, not a licensed facility.

CORE RULES & REFERENCES

- OAC 5123-9-33 — Shared Living under the Individual Options waiver (definition, provider qualifications, payment; Appendix A has service codes and rates).
- OAC 5123-2-09 — Provider certification, independent providers; OAC 5123-2-08 — agency providers.
- OAC 5123-9-02 — HCBS waivers, ensuring the suitability of services and service settings (the HCBS Settings rule).
- OAC 5123-9-06 — funding ranges and the Ohio Developmental Disabilities Profile (ODDP).

You can do this.

Opening a Shared Living home is real work — but it's a real, walkable path, and people across Ohio do it every day, giving someone a real home instead of a placement in an institution. You don't have to be a lawyer or hire a consultant, and you don't need to chase a group-home license that isn't available. You need a safe home, a good heart, and a clear map — and now you have the map. Whether you start as an independent provider or build an agency, this guide takes you from your very first question all the way to your first payment.

Take it one step at a time, verify the current details with the State as you go, and lean on your county board and the DODD Provider Support Center — that's what they're there for.

Prepared for PolicyReady.org. Grounded in Ohio DODD rules and the Ohio Administrative Code (Chapter 5123) as of 2026. This guide is general information, not legal, tax, or billing advice. Requirements, rates, and codes change — always verify current details with the State of Ohio before you act.